BOTÂNORA

N° 02



The Tea Atlas

The six styles of Camellia sinensis, leaf to cup

PDF GUIDE · 40 PAGES

BOTÂNORA · GUIDE N° 02

The Tea Atlas

The six styles of Camellia sinensis, leaf to cup

White, green, yellow, oolong, black and dark: six families, one plant. This atlas explains how each process transforms the Camellia sinensis leaf, where each style comes from and how to recognise it by leaf, colour and taste.

There is nothing to memorise. Read one chapter at a time with a cup beside you, use the tasting sheet and return to the glossary whenever a term comes up. At the end, twelve recipes by style, profiles of 24 famous teas and a practical chapter on tools, water and gongfu.



01

Understand the process

Withering, fixing, rolling, oxidation: four steps explain almost everything.

02

Taste with method

The tasting sheet trains your palate faster than any list.

03

Buy better

Knowing grades, origins and harvests prevents disappointment.

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CHAPTER I

The plant

One species, a thousand teas

All true tea comes from Camellia sinensis, an evergreen shrub that, left alone, grows into a tree. What changes from cup to cup is the variety, the place, the moment of harvest and, above all, what happens to the leaf after picking.

01 Camellia sinensis

02 From leaf to cup

03 The six families



THE PLANT

Camellia sinensis

Two main varieties, hundreds of cultivars and one detail that defines quality: what gets picked.

Var. sinensis

Small leaf, cold-hardy

Native to south-east China. Small, delicate leaves, ideal for aromatic greens, whites and oolongs. Thrives at altitude and in temperate climates.

WHERE	China, Japan, Taiwan, Darjeeling
PROFILE	Floral, fresh, subtle

Var. assamica

Large leaf, heat-loving

Found in Assam (India) and Yunnan (China). Large leaves rich in polyphenols, producing full-bodied blacks and the base of pu-erh.

WHERE	Assam, Yunnan, Kenya, Sri Lanka
PROFILE	Malt, body, intensity

What gets picked

Quality starts with the plucking standard. The classic is **one bud and two leaves**: the youngest, tenderest part of the shoot, rich in amino acids and aromas. Bud-only picking gives rare teas such as Silver Needle; larger, older leaves give simpler, fuller teas.

The plant grows in waves, called **flushes**. In Darjeeling, the first harvest (March and April) is light and floral; the second (May and June) brings the famous muscatel aroma; the autumnal is rounder.

STANDARD	WHAT IT IS	RESULT
Bud only	Closed buds covered in down	Rare, delicate whites and yellows
Bud + 1 leaf	Fine plucking	High-grade greens and whites
Bud + 2 leaves	The classic standard	Most good teas
Mature leaves	Coarse plucking	Open-leaf oolongs, dark teas, everyday teas

PROCESSING

From leaf to cup

Four steps explain almost every difference between teas. The rest are variations on them.

STEP	WHAT HAPPENS	EFFECT IN THE CUP
Withering	The leaf rests and loses water; it becomes pliable and starts developing aromas.	More sweetness and fragrance
Fixing	Heat (pan, steam or oven) deactivates enzymes and locks oxidation.	Keeps greenness and freshness
Rolling	Twisting or rolling breaks cells and brings juices to the surface.	Shape, extraction and intensity
Oxidation	Oxygen reacts with polyphenols and darkens the leaf.	Body, colour and malty notes
Yellowing	Warm leaf is wrapped and sealed (men huang).	The softness of yellow tea
Piling	Moistened leaf ferments in piles (wo dui).	Earthy, smooth ripe pu-erh
Drying and roasting	Fixes the result; roasting adds toasty notes.	Stability and toasty notes

Which teas go through what

FAMILY	WITHER	FIX	ROLL	OXIDISE	SPECIAL
White	long	no	no	light, natural	–
Green	short	yes	yes	no	–
Yellow	short	yes	light	minimal	yellowing
Oolong	yes	yes, midway	yes	partial	tossing, roast
Black	yes	no	heavy	full	–
Dark	yes	yes	yes	variable	fermentation

MIND THE TERM

Oxidation is not fermentation. Oxidation is the leaf's own chemistry; fermentation, found only in dark teas, involves microorganisms.

OVERVIEW

The six families

A quick map before the deep dive. Average values; every tea has its exceptions.

FAMILY	OXIDATION	LIQUOR	TYPICAL TASTE	EXAMPLES
White	5–15%	pale straw	honey, hay, white flowers	Silver Needle, Bai Mu Dan
Green	0–3%	yellow-green	vegetal, chestnut, seaweed	Long Jing, Sencha
Yellow	≈ 5%	golden yellow	soft, sweetish, no harshness	Jun Shan Yin Zhen
Oolong	15–70%	gold to amber	orchid, fruit, roast	Tie Guan Yin, Da Hong Pao
Black	90–100%	copper to red	malt, cocoa, dried fruit	Assam, Keemun, Darjeeling
Dark	variable	amber to near black	earth, wood, leather	Pu-erh, Liu Bao

Notice how oxidation explains much of the journey of the liquor, from straw to red, and of the taste, from vegetal to malty. But not all of it: a heavily roasted oolong can look darker than a light black, and a young raw pu-erh can taste like an intense green.

What defines a tea is not the plant but what is done to it in the first 48 hours.

CHAPTER II

The six styles

Family portraits

Each family has its own logic, geography and a handful of classic teas that calibrate the palate. Start with the classics: they are the yardstick for everything else.

01 White

02 Green

03 Yellow

04 Oolong

05 Black

06 Dark teas and pu-erh



FAMILY 01

White tea

Minimal intervention: wither and dry. Born in Fujian, it is the tea closest to the living leaf.

With no fixing or rolling, the leaf withers slowly for up to three days and oxidises a little on its own. The result is delicate and sweet, with honey and hay notes. Whites age well: kept for years, they gain date and wood notes.

Bai Hao Yin Zhen

Silver Needle

Buds only, covered in silver down. Honey, cucumber, white flowers.

Bai Mu Dan

White Peony

Bud and two leaves. More body, hay and peach notes.

Shou Mei

Long-life eyebrow

More mature leaves. Robust, fruity, great when aged.

BREWING

METHOD	DOSE	WATER	TIME
Western	3 g / 200 ml	80–85 °C	4–5 min
Gongfu	5 g / 100 ml	85–90 °C	20 s, +10 s each

BOTÂNORA TIP

Whites are forgiving. If you overshoot the time they rarely turn bitter: try long steeps and watch the honey come through.

FAMILY 02

Green tea

Heat right after picking locks oxidation. China uses the pan; Japan uses steam.

CHINESE SCHOOL: PAN

Fixed in a hot pan or drum. Toasty notes of chestnut and green bean. Whole, beautiful leaves in the cup.

JAPANESE SCHOOL: STEAM

Steamed for seconds. Marine notes of grass and spinach; intense green colour and umami.

TEA	ORIGIN	PROFILE
Long Jing	Hangzhou, Zhejiang	Flat leaves; chestnut, toasted soy
Bi Luo Chun	Jiangsu	Fine spirals, fruity and floral
Huangshan Mao Feng	Anhui	Delicate, orchid, sweet
Sencha	Shizuoka, Kagoshima	Grass, sea, lively astringency
Gyokuro	Uji, Yame	Shaded; deep umami, sweet broth
Genmaicha	Japan	With toasted rice; popcorn, comfort
Hojicha	Japan	Roasted; caramel, low caffeine

BREWING

TEA	DOSE	WATER	TIME
Chinese	3 g / 200 ml	75–80 °C	2–3 min
Sencha	4 g / 200 ml	70–80 °C	1–1,5 min
Gyokuro	5 g / 60 ml	50–60 °C	2 min

CLASSIC MISTAKE

Boiling water is the most common mistake with greens: it scorches the leaf and releases bitterness. Boiled it? Wait 3 to 4 minutes with the lid off.

FAMILY 03

Yellow tea

The rarest of the six: a green that goes through slow sealing and loses its edge.

After fixing, the still-warm leaf is wrapped in cloth or paper and sealed for hours or days (men huang). In that warm moisture it yellows slightly and the harsher compounds soften. The result has the sweetness of green tea without its aggressive vegetal side.

The technique is laborious and the market small, so many producers switched to green. Finding an authentic yellow is a small event.

Jun Shan Yin Zhen

Hunan

Buds from an island in Lake Dongting. Sweet, soft, notes of sweetcorn.

Huoshan Huangya

Anhui

Bud and leaf. Chestnut, sweet hay.

Meng Ding Huangya

Sichuan

From one of China's oldest tea mountains. Delicate and floral.

BREWING

METHOD	DOSE	WATER	TIME
Western	3 g / 200 ml	75–80 °C	2–3 min
Glass	3 g / 250 ml	80 °C	sip and top up

BOTÂNORA TIP

Brew in a tall glass: the buds stand upright and "dance". In China, that is part of the appreciation.

FAMILY 04

Oolong

The middle ground: partially oxidised and worked by hand in cycles of tossing and resting.

The leaf is tossed to bruise its edges, rests, oxidises a little, and is tossed again. When the master decides, heat stops the oxidation. Then comes rolling (into balls or strips) and often a charcoal roast. The range is huge: from nearly green and floral to dark and roasted.

TEA	ORIGIN	OXIDATION	PROFILE
Tie Guan Yin	Anxi, Fujian	15–30%	Orchid, lilac, butter
Dong Ding	Nantou, Taiwan	25–35%	Medium roast, nuts, honey
High Mountain	Taiwan	15–25%	Creamy, floral, white fruit
Da Hong Pao	Wuyi, Fujian	40–60%	Mineral, roasted, cocoa
Dan Cong	Fenghuang, Guangdong	30–50%	Peach, orchid, honey
Oriental Beauty	Hsinchu, Taiwan	50–70%	Honey and muscatel, from insect bites

BREWING

METHOD	DOSE	WATER	TIME
Western	3 g / 200 ml	85–95 °C	3–5 min
Gongfu	6 g / 100 ml	95 °C	20–30 s; 5 to 8 steeps

BOTÂNORA TIP

Ball-rolled oolongs need room: the leaves unfurl up to five times their size. Do not cram the infuser.

FAMILY 05

Black tea

Full oxidation: body, tannins and malt. In China it is called "red tea" after the colour of the liquor.

TEA	ORIGIN	PROFILE	WITH MILK?
Assam	India, Brahmaputra valley	Malt, strong body	Yes
Darjeeling	India, Himalayas	Light, floral, muscatel	No
Ceylon	Sri Lanka	Citrusy, bright	Optional
Keemun	Anhui, China	Cocoa, plum, a hint of smoke	Optional
Dian Hong	Yunnan, China	Honey, pepper, golden buds	No
Lapsang Souchong	Wuyi, Fujian	Pine-smoked	Optional
Kenya (CTC)	Kenya	Intense, quick, full	Yes

Whole leaf or CTC?

Orthodox blacks are rolled and keep the leaf more whole: complex aroma, slower extraction. CTC (crush, tear, curl) crushes the leaf into granules: it extracts in 2 to 3 minutes with strong colour, ideal for bags and chai.

METHOD	DOSE	WATER	TIME
Whole leaf	2,5 g / 200 ml	90–100 °C	3–5 min
CTC	2 g / 200 ml	100 °C	2–3 min
Darjeeling 1st flush	2,5 g / 200 ml	85–90 °C	3 min

BOTÂNORA TIP

First-flush Darjeeling is almost an oolong: water below the boil keeps its delicacy from turning astringent.

FAMILY 06

Dark teas and pu-erh

The only family fermented by microorganisms. Pressed into cakes and bricks, it ages like wine.

Sheng (raw)

Natural ageing

Leaf fixed, rolled, sun-dried and pressed. Young, it is intense and bitter like a strong green; with years of storage it becomes sweet, fruity and woody.

Shou (ripe)

Accelerated fermentation

A technique developed in the 1970s in Yunnan: the leaf is moistened and piled for weeks (wo dui). Earthy, smooth, dark liquor, almost no bitterness.

OTHER DARK TEAS

TEA	ORIGIN	PROFILE
Liu Bao	Guangxi	Wood, betel, a minty coolness with age
Fu Zhuan	Hunan	Brick with "golden flowers" (Eurotium fungus); sweet, herbal

BREWING

METHOD	DOSE	WATER	TIME
Western	4 g / 250 ml	95–100 °C	2–4 min
Gongfu	7 g / 100 ml	100 °C	10–20 s; 8 to 15 steeps

BOTÂNORA TIP

Always do a 10-second rinse with boiling water and discard it. It wakes the pressed leaf and washes away storage dust.

PRACTICAL

To loosen leaves from a cake, use a pu-erh knife or a thin pick from the side, following the layers. Avoid crumbling it.

CHAPTER III

Tea map

Where each style is born

Climate, altitude, soil and tradition shape tea as much as processing does. This chapter tours the world's main producing regions and recalls that Brazil also has its own history with Camellia.

01 Producing regions

02 Tea in Brazil



MAP

Producing regions

An itinerary in table form: the country, the region, what it does best.

COUNTRY	REGION	SPECIALTY	CLIMATE AND ALTITUDE
China	Fujian	Whites, Wuyi and Anxi oolongs, Lapsang	Humid mountains
China	Zhejiang · Anhui	Classic greens, Keemun	Temperate hills
China	Yunnan	Pu-erh, Dian Hong, ancient trees	Subtropical plateau
China	Hunan · Guangxi	Yellows, Fu Zhuan, Liu Bao	Humid, warm
Taiwan	Nantou · Alishan · Hsinchu	High-mountain oolongs, Oriental Beauty	Up to 2,500 m
Japan	Shizuoka · Uji · Kagoshima	Sencha, gyokuro, matcha	Temperate, mists
South Korea	Boseong · Jeju	Delicate greens	Coastal
India	Darjeeling	Light high-grown blacks	600 to 2,000 m
India	Assam · Nilgiri	Malty blacks, CTC	Tropical plain; hills
Sri Lanka	Nuwara Eliya · Uva · Dimbula	Bright, citrusy Ceylon	Low to high grown
Nepal	Ilam · Dhankuta	Darjeeling-style blacks and whites	Himalayas
Kenya	Kericho · Nandi	Full CTC, greens and purples	Equatorial highlands
Vietnã	Thai Nguyen · Ha Giang	Greens, ancient-tree teas	Mountainous

MAP

Tea in Brazil

Few people know it, but Brazil was once a significant producer of Camellia sinensis.

Commercial tea production in Brazil centred on the Ribeira Valley in southern São Paulo state, around Registro. Japanese immigrants brought the crop to the region in the 20th century, and for decades it supplied national brands and exports, mostly black tea.

With international competition, many farms closed. Today small growers are reviving the crop with artisanal processing, and there are quality Brazilian greens, blacks, oolongs and whites, plus trials in other hill regions of the South and Southeast.

Tasting a Brazilian tea is a good way to understand terroir: the same plant, in a warm, humid, low-altitude climate, gives profiles quite different from the Asian classics.

Isn't yerba mate tea?

In Portuguese we call almost any infusion "chá", but yerba mate (Ilex paraguariensis) is a different plant, native to southern Brazil, Paraguay and Argentina. It also contains caffeine, which is rare among tisanes. There is a whole guide about it in the collection.

> **MINDFUL BUYING**
> When buying, look for region and harvest on the label. Tea with no stated origin is usually a blend from several sources.

CHAPTER IV

Tasting

Training the palate

Tasting is paying attention in the right order. With a simple method and a sheet, in a few weeks you start recognising families, origins and flaws.

01 Six-step method

02 Brewing parameters

03 Tasting sheet

04 Buying and storage



TASTING

Six-step method

1. **Dry leaf.** Look at colour, shape, wholeness and sheen. Broken leaves extract fast; whole leaves slowly. Smell inside the bag.
2. **Warm and smell.** Put the leaf in a pre-warmed vessel, cover and shake. The "woken" aroma reveals a lot.
3. **Brew by measure.** Use a scale and a timer. Without a standard, you compare brewing, not teas.
4. **Liquor.** Colour, brightness and clarity. Cloudy can mean broken leaf or hard water; bright means freshness.
5. **Slurp.** Sip with a light sucking noise: air spreads the tea across the mouth and carries aroma to the nose. Note sweet, bitter, sour, umami, body and aftertaste.
6. **Infused leaf.** Spread the leaves on a saucer. Whole and supple means care; dark edges mean oxidation; a burnt smell means over-roasting.

Aroma vocabulary

FAMILY	DESCRIPTORS	WHERE IT APPEARS
Vegetal	grass, pea, spinach, seaweed	Japanese greens
Floral	orchid, lilac, jasmine, orange blossom	Light oolongs, whites
Fruity	peach, apricot, raisin, plum	Dan Cong, Darjeeling, Keemun
Sweet	honey, caramel, vanilla, malt	Blacks, aged whites
Roasted	chestnut, bread, cocoa, coffee	Long Jing, Da Hong Pao, hojicha
Earthy	forest floor, wood, leather, mushroom	Pu-erh, Liu Bao

TASTING

Brewing parameters

Starting points. Adjust one parameter at a time: time first, then dose, temperature last.

FAMILY	WESTERN (G / 200 ML)	°C	TIME	GONGFU (G / 100 ML)	STEEPS
White	3	80–85	4–5 min	5	4–6
Chinese green	3	75–80	2–3 min	4	3–4
Japanese green	4	70–80	1–1,5 min	5	3
Yellow	3	75–80	2–3 min	4	3–4
Light oolong	3	85–90	3–4 min	6	6–8
Roasted oolong	3	95	3–5 min	6	6–8
Black	2,5	90–100	3–5 min	5	3–5
Pu-erh	4	95–100	2–4 min	7	8–15

Water

Filtered, neutral-tasting water with little limescale makes more difference than most people think. Very hard water mutes aromas and clouds the liquor; distilled water makes tea flat. Never reboil the same water again and again: it loses oxygen and the tea tastes lifeless.

Vessels

VESSEL	BEST FOR
Porcelain gaiwan	Everything; neutral and great for tasting
Glass teapot	Whites, Chinese greens, yellows
Kyusu (Japanese side-handle pot)	Sencha and gyokuro
Clay teapot (Yixing)	Roasted oolongs and pu-erh, one type per pot
Enamelled cast-iron pot	Blacks; keeps heat

TO PRINT

Tasting sheet

Print as many as you like. Comparing two teas side by side with the same sheet teaches more than ten random tastings.

TEA / ORIGIN

DATE · SUPPLIER

DRY LEAF (COLOUR, SHAPE, AROMA)

BREWING (G · ML · °C · TIME)

LIQUOR (COLOUR, CLARITY)

AROMA

TASTE (SWEET, BITTER, SOUR, UMAMI)

TEXTURE AND BODY

AFTERTASTE

INFUSED LEAF

RESTEEPS

FREE NOTES

SWEETNESS ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

ASTRINGENCY ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

INTENSITY ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

OVERALL ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

PRACTICAL

Buying and storage

Reading black tea grades

CODE	MEANING
OP	Orange Pekoe: whole leaf, no tips
FOP	Flowery Orange Pekoe: whole leaf with some tips
TGFOP	Tippy Golden FOP: many golden tips
FTGFOP	Finest TGFOP: a superior selection
BOP	Broken Orange Pekoe: broken leaf, quick extraction
Fannings · Dust	Fine particles for bags
CTC	Granules; strong and quick

Signs of a good tea

- Origin, harvest and packing date stated.
- Leaves with lively colour and a clear aroma when you open the bag.
- Little dust at the bottom of the bag.
- Opaque, well-sealed packaging.

Storage

FAMILY	BEST WITHIN	CARE
Greens and yellows	6 to 12 months	Cool and dark; fridge only if sealed, never opened cold
Whites	years	Dry and odour-free; they age well
Oolongs	1 to 2 years	Roasted ones last longer than light ones
Blacks	2 years	Opaque, airtight tin
Pu-erh	decades	Needs to breathe: ventilated, dark, odour-free

NOTE

Tea absorbs smells easily. Never store it near coffee, spices or cleaning products.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Sixty terms to read labels, talk with growers and understand this atlas.

Astringency · A drying, puckering sensation caused by tannins and catechins. Not the same as bitterness.

Assamica · Large-leaf variety of Camellia sinensis, suited to heat; the base of Assam, Kenyan and Yunnan blacks.

Bai hao · Fine white down covering the buds; a sign of young picking.

Bancha · Japanese green tea from later harvests, larger leaves and a simple taste.

Blend · A mix of teas, or tea with other ingredients, made for a consistent profile.

Bud · The still-closed leaf at the tip of the shoot; the most delicate part of the harvest.

Catechins · Polyphenols abundant in green and white tea; linked to flavour and astringency.

Chawan · The bowl used to prepare and drink matcha.

Cold brew · Extraction in cold water for several hours; fewer tannins and more sweetness.

Body · The feeling of weight and texture of the liquor in the mouth.

CTC · Crush, tear, curl: a method that crushes the leaf into granules; the base of tea bags.

Cultivar · A selected variety propagated by cloning, such as Yabukita or Qing Xin.

Dan cong · Oolongs from Fenghuang (Guangdong), famous for specific floral and fruity aromas.

Decoction · Simmering the ingredient in water; used for roots, barks and spices.

Rinse · A quick pour of water discarded before the first steep; common with pu-erh and oolong.

Fannings · Small leaf particles, used in fast-brewing tea bags.

Fixing (kill-green) · Heating that deactivates enzymes and stops oxidation (sha qing).

Flush · Each growth spurt of the plant in the year; in Darjeeling, the first is the most delicate.

Infused leaf · The leaf after steeping; it reveals quality, wholeness and processing.

Gaiwan · A lidded bowl with saucer, used for short, repeated steeps.

Genmaicha · Japanese green tea with toasted brown rice.

Gongfu cha · Brewing with lots of leaf, little water and many short steeps.

Grade · Classification by leaf size and wholeness (OP, BOP, fannings).

Gyokuro · Japanese green tea shaded for about three weeks; intense umami.

Hojicha · Roasted Japanese green tea; brown, toasty and low in caffeine.

Infusion · Hot water over the leaves, off the heat.

Kabusecha · Green tea covered for one to two weeks before harvest; between sencha and gyokuro.

L-theanine · An amino acid almost unique to tea; adds sweetness and umami and modulates caffeine.

Liquor · The brewed tea: colour, brightness and clarity of the infusion.

Maocha · Processed, dried leaf before pressing; the base of pu-erh.

Matcha · Tencha ground to powder; you drink the whole leaf.

Men huang · Sealed, moist "yellowing" that gives yellow tea its colour and softness.

Withering · Controlled water loss from the fresh leaf, making it pliable.

Oolong · Partially oxidised tea, worked in cycles of tossing and resting.

Orange Pekoe · A whole-leaf grade; nothing to do with oranges.

Oxidation · An enzymatic reaction that darkens the leaf and transforms aromas.

Pekoe · Young leaves near the bud, used in grade names.

Pu-erh · Dark tea from Yunnan, raw (sheng) or ripe (shou), often pressed.

Resteep · Using the same leaves again; oolongs and pu-erh give many.

Rolling · Twisting or rolling the leaf to break cells and give it shape.

Sencha · Japan's most common green tea, steamed to fix it.

Sheng · Raw pu-erh, which ages slowly over years.

Shou · Ripe pu-erh, with accelerated pile fermentation (wo dui).

Sinensis · Small-leaf, cold-hardy variety; the base of Chinese and Japanese teas.

Tannins · Compounds that give structure and astringency; extract more with time and heat.

Tencha · Shaded leaf, stems and veins removed, that becomes matcha.

Terroir · Soil, climate, altitude and care that give tea its identity.

Tisane · An infusion of plants other than Camellia sinensis.

Roasting · Final heating that adds toasty notes and stabilises oolongs and hojicha.

Umami · Savoury-sweet taste linked to amino acids; strong in shaded greens.

Wo dui · Wet piling that ferments ripe pu-erh.

Yixing · Porous clay teapots from China, each devoted to one tea type.

Yin zhen · "Silver needle": buds only; a name for top white and yellow teas.

Zhenghe and Fuding · Counties in Fujian, the birthplace of white tea.

Brightness · Liveliness of liquor and acidity; a mark of freshness.

Aftertaste · What stays in the mouth after swallowing.

Hui gan · A returning sweetness in the throat after the sip; prized in pu-erh and oolong.

Leafhopper · An insect whose bites give Oriental Beauty its honey notes.

Lapsang · A Wuyi black tea smoked over pine.

Dark tea (heicha) · The post-fermented family: pu-erh, Liu Bao, Fu Zhuan.

CHAPTER V

Recipes by style

From white to dark

Twelve preparations that show the best of each family: gongfu, kyusu, glass, simmered, with milk and iced. Each recipe names the ideal leaf but works with equivalents.

01 Bai Mu Dan in a Gaiwan

02 Simmered Shou Mei

03 Long Jing in a Glass

04 Sencha in a Kyusu

05 Yellow Tea in a Gaiwan

06 Gongfu Tie Guan Yin

07 Homemade Bubble Tea

08 Spring Darjeeling

09 Po Cha: Tibetan Butter Tea

10 London Fog

11 Pu-erh with Tangerine Peel

12 Russian Zavarka



01 Bai Mu Dan in a Gaiwan

The bud-and-leaf white, in short steeps.

Hot · 15 min · 5 small cups · Caffeinated · Intermediate

INGREDIENTS

4 g	Bai Mu Dan
100 ml	water at 85 °C, per round

Finish. Compare the colour: from straw to gold.

METHOD

1. Warm the gaiwan and cups with hot water.
2. Add the leaves, cover and shake: smell the hay and honey.
3. Steeps of 30 s, 30 s, 45 s, 1 min and 1 min 30 s.
4. Pour each round out completely, leaving no water on the leaves.

BARISTA TIP Whites take more heat than you think: below 80 °C they turn watery.

02 Simmered Shou Mei

Aged white simmered, as in Fujian.

Hot · 12 min · 2 cups · Caffeinated · Easy

INGREDIENTS

5 g	Shou Mei or aged white
500 ml	water
2	dried dates (optional)

Finish. A date in the cup.

METHOD

1. Make a quick first steep in hot water and drink it.
2. Put the same leaves in a small pan with the cold water and dates.
3. Simmer gently for 5 to 8 min. Strain.

BARISTA TIP Only aged whites do well simmered; young leaves turn bitter.

03 Long Jing in a Glass

Hangzhou's green, leaves dancing.

Hot · 3 min · 1 glass · 250 ml · Caffeinated · Easy

INGREDIENTS

3 g	Long Jing (Dragon Well)
250 ml	water at 80 °C

Finish. Leaves standing like needles.

METHOD

1. Pour a third of the water into the glass, then add the leaves.
2. Wait 30 s for the leaves to open.
3. Top up along the rim in a high stream.
4. Drink once the leaves sink; top up when a third is left.

BARISTA TIP Water first protects the delicate leaf from heat shock.

04 Sencha in a Kyusu

The Japanese way, down to the last drop.

Hot · 4 min · 2 cups · 160 ml · Caffeinated · Intermediate

INGREDIENTS

5 g	sencha
160 ml	water at 70 °C

Finish. Second steep of 20 s, hotter.

METHOD

1. Boil the water and pour it into the cups: they warm up and the water cools by about 10 °C.
2. Put the sencha in the kyusu and pour in the water from the cups.
3. Steep 1 min without stirring.
4. Pour alternating between cups, down to the last drop, which is the most concentrated.

BARISTA TIP Pouring between vessels is the Japanese thermometer: each transfer drops about 10 °C.

05 Yellow Tea in a Gaiwan

The rarest of the six styles.

Hot · 10 min · 4 small cups · Caffeinated · Intermediate

INGREDIENTS

3 g	yellow tea (Huoshan Huangya, Junshan Yinzhen)
100 ml	water at 80 °C, per round

METHOD

1. Warm the gaiwan.
2. Steeps of 40 s, 40 s, 1 min and 1 min 30 s.
3. Taste the first slowly: sweet, of fresh corn and chestnut.

BARISTA TIP The "smothering" (men huang) removes green tea's grassy edge. Buy from a trusted seller: much "yellow" is ordinary green.

06 Gongfu Tie Guan Yin

Orchid, butter and many rounds.

Hot · 20 min · 8 small cups · Caffeinated · Technique

INGREDIENTS

7 g	Tie Guan Yin
100 ml	water at 95 °C, per round

Finish. Open the leaves at the end: whole, with oxidised edges.

METHOD

1. Warm everything. Leaves into the gaiwan; 5 s rinse and discard.
2. Steeps of 20, 20, 25, 30, 40, 50 s, 1 min and 1 min 30 s.
3. Use a pitcher (cha hai) so every cup has the same strength.
4. Smell the gaiwan lid between rounds.

BARISTA TIP The rolled balls open until they fill the gaiwan; 7 g looks small but is the right measure.

07 Homemade Bubble Tea

Taiwanese milk tea with tapioca pearls.

Iced · 40 min · 2 glasses · Caffeinated · With milk · Intermediate

INGREDIENTS

6 g	roasted oolong or Assam
300 ml	boiling water
60 g	tapioca pearls
3 tbsp	brown sugar
200 ml	milk

Finish. A wide straw.

METHOD

1. Cook the pearls as packaged (20 to 30 min). Drain and mix with the brown sugar and 2 tbsp hot water.
2. Steep the tea strong for 5 min, strain and cool.
3. In the glass: pearls with syrup, ice, tea and milk.

BARISTA TIP Pearls harden in the fridge: make only what you will drink within 4 hours.

08 Spring Darjeeling

The "champagne of teas", no milk.

Hot · 4 min · 1 pot · 400 ml · Caffeinated · Easy

INGREDIENTS

6 g	first-flush Darjeeling
400 ml	water at 90 °C

Finish. Nothing: no milk, no sugar.

METHOD

1. Warm the pot.
2. Steep 2 min 30 s to 3 min. First flush turns bitter quickly.
3. Strain it all into another pot or cups.

BARISTA TIP Second flush (summer) takes boiling water and 4 min; it has muscatel notes.

09 Po Cha: Tibetan Butter Tea

Dark, salty and creamy: the mountain tea.

Hot · 15 min · 2 cups · Caffeinated · With milk · Intermediate

INGREDIENTS

5 g	shou pu-erh or another pressed dark tea
500 ml	water
1 tbsp	unsalted butter
100 ml	milk
1 pinch	salt

METHOD

1. Simmer the tea in the water for 10 min until very dark. Strain.
2. Blend the hot tea with the butter, milk and salt for 30 s (lid ajar, a cloth on top).
3. Serve at once, frothy.

BARISTA TIP In Tibet the tea is churned in a wooden cylinder. Salt is part of the flavour: start small, as with a broth.

10 London Fog

Earl Grey, frothed milk and vanilla.

Hot · 6 min · 1 mug · 250 ml · Caffeinated · With milk · Easy

INGREDIENTS

3 g	Earl Grey
120 ml	boiling water
130 ml	milk
1 tsp	vanilla syrup or honey

Finish. Dried lavender on top, if you like.

METHOD

1. Steep the Earl Grey for 4 min, concentrated. Strain.
2. Sweeten the tea.
3. Heat and froth the milk and pour on top.

BARISTA TIP It was born in Vancouver, despite the name. Works with rooibos for a caffeine-free version.

11 Pu-erh with Tangerine Peel

Earthy and citrusy, for after dinner.

Hot · 15 min · 4 small cups · Caffeinated · Intermediate

INGREDIENTS

5 g	shou pu-erh
2 g	dried tangerine peel (chenpi)
100 ml	boiling water, per round

Finish. Coffee colour, no bitterness.

METHOD

1. Break the pu-erh carefully without crumbling it.
2. Two quick 5 s rinses; discard.
3. Add the peel. Steeps of 15, 15, 20, 30, 45 s and 1 min.

BARISTA TIP Dry tangerine peel at home: no pith, 3 days in the shade or 1 h in a low oven.

12 Russian Zavarka

A concentrate in the pot, diluted in the cup.

Hot · 10 min · 6 to 8 cups · Caffeinated · Easy

INGREDIENTS

10 g	black tea (Keemun, Ceylon or Russian blend)
200 ml	boiling water
to taste	hot water to dilute, lemon, jam

Finish. Lemon or a spoon of jam in the cup.

METHOD

1. Steep the tea in little water for 5 to 7 min: that is the zavarka.
2. Put 30 to 50 ml of concentrate in each cup.
3. Top up with hot water. Everyone picks their strength.

BARISTA TIP The ideal way to serve many people without a big pot: the concentrate lasts 1 hour.

CHAPTER VI

24 famous teas

Profiles to recognise and buy

The names you will meet on menus and in specialty tea shops. For each: origin, style, brewing and the notes to look for in the cup.



Silver Needle

Fujian, China

Only buds covered in silvery down.

STYLE	White
BREW	85 °C · 3 min
NOTES	melon, honey, meadow flowers

Bai Mu Dan (White Peony)

Fujian, China

A bud with two leaves, more body than Silver Needle.

STYLE	White
BREW	85 °C · 3 min
NOTES	hay, apricot, honey

Long Jing (Dragon Well)

Hangzhou, China

Leaves pressed flat in the wok by hand.

STYLE	Green
BREW	80 °C · 2 min
NOTES	roasted chestnut, pea

Bi Luo Chun

Jiangsu, China

Fine downy spirals, grown among fruit trees.

STYLE	Green
BREW	75 °C · 2 min
NOTES	fruity, floral, fresh

Huangshan Mao Feng

Anhui, China

Mountain leaves shaped like a beak.

STYLE	Green
BREW	80 °C · 2 min
NOTES	orchid, sweet, light

Gyokuro

Uji and Yame, Japan

Shaded for weeks like matcha, but as leaf.

STYLE	Green
BREW	55–60 °C · 2 min
NOTES	intense umami, broth

Sencha

Shizuoka and Kagoshima, Japan

Japan's everyday tea, steamed.

STYLE	Green
BREW	70 °C · 1 min
NOTES	grass, seaweed, citrus

Hojicha

Kyoto, Japan

Bancha and stems roasted at high heat.

STYLE	Roasted green
BREW	95 °C · 30 s
NOTES	caramel, light coffee, wood

Junshan Yin Zhen

Hunan, China

Buds from an island in Dongting lake.

STYLE	Yellow
BREW	80 °C · 2 min
NOTES	sweetcorn, chestnut

Tie Guan Yin

Anxi, Fujian

Rolled balls, the "Iron Goddess".

STYLE	Light oolong
BREW	95 °C · gongfu
NOTES	orchid, lilac, butter

Da Hong Pao

Wuyi Mountains, Fujian

The "Big Red Robe" of the cliffs.

STYLE	Roasted oolong
BREW	100 °C · gongfu
NOTES	mineral, cacao, dried fruit

Dong Ding

Nantou, Taiwan

A rolled, medium-roast oolong.

STYLE	Oolong
BREW	95 °C · gongfu
NOTES	nuts, honey, bread

Oriental Beauty

Hsinchu, Taiwan

Leaves bitten by leafhoppers, which creates honey notes.

STYLE	Dark oolong
BREW	90 °C · 3 min
NOTES	honey, peach, muscatel

High Mountain (Alishan)

Chiayi, Taiwan

Grown above 1,000 m, light and creamy.

STYLE	Light oolong
BREW	95 °C · gongfu
NOTES	white flowers, cream

Darjeeling

West Bengal, India

Himalayan gardens; very different harvests.

STYLE	Black
BREW	90–95 °C · 3 min
NOTES	muscatel, flowers, grape

Assam

Assam, India

Hot lowlands; the base of breakfast teas.

STYLE	Black
BREW	100 °C · 4 min
NOTES	malt, molasses, full-bodied

Ceylon Nuwara Eliya

Sri Lanka

The highest and lightest of the Ceylons.

STYLE	Black
BREW	95 °C · 3 min
NOTES	citrus, floral, bright

Keemun

Anhui, China

A classic Chinese black, base of many English Breakfasts.

STYLE	Black
BREW	95 °C · 3 min
NOTES	cocoa, light smoke, plum

Dian Hong

Yunnan, China

Lots of golden buds, sweet and smooth.

STYLE	Black
BREW	95 °C · 3 min
NOTES	sweet potato, malt, pepper

Lapsang Souchong

Wuyi Mountains, Fujian

Dried over pinewood fires.

STYLE	Smoked black
BREW	95 °C · 3 min
NOTES	smoke, resin, bacon

Sheng Pu-erh

Yunnan, China

Pressed raw; ages for decades.

STYLE	Dark
BREW	95 °C · gongfu
NOTES	young: bitter and fruity; old: wood

Shou Pu-erh

Yunnan, China

Accelerated fermentation in damp piles.

STYLE	Dark
BREW	100 °C · gongfu
NOTES	earth, cocoa, coffee

Liu Bao

Guangxi, China

A dark tea aged in bamboo baskets.

STYLE	Dark
BREW	100 °C · gongfu
NOTES	betel, wood, herbs

Matcha

Uji and Nishio, Japan

Shaded tencha ground on stone.

STYLE	Powdered green
BREW	75–80 °C · whisked
NOTES	umami, cream, sweet grass

AT HOME

Tools

You do not need to buy everything. A pot with an infuser and a gaiwan cover all six styles.

TOOL	BEST FOR	WHY	PRICE
Pot with infuser	blacks, herbs, blends	Removes the leaves at the right time	$
Gaiwan	whites, oolongs, pu-erh	Short steeps, leaf in view	$
Kyusu	Japanese greens	Fine filter for steamed leaf	$$
Tall glass	Chinese greens, yellows	Shows the leaf; no straining	$
Yixing clay pot	a single type of oolong or pu-erh	Porous clay holds flavour	$$$
Variable-temperature kettle	all	Ends the guesswork	$$
0.1 g scale	all	Leaves vary hugely in volume	$

Recommended starter kit

- A 500 ml glass pot with a fine steel infuser.
- A 100 to 120 ml porcelain gaiwan.
- A 0.1 g kitchen scale.
- A cooking thermometer or a temperature kettle.

BOTÂNORA TIP

White porcelain inside is best for tasting: it holds no flavour and shows the true colour of the liquor.

AT HOME

The water

Tea is 99% water. Bad water spoils the best leaf.

WATER TYPE	EFFECT ON TEA	USE?
Chlorinated tap	Pool smell, dull aroma	Filter first
Filtered (carbon)	Neutral, good for almost everything	Yes
Light mineral (TDS < 100 mg/L)	Sweetness and brightness	Ideal
Hard mineral (> 250 mg/L)	Cloudy, dull, heavy	Avoid
Distilled or RO	Flat, no body	Mix with mineral

Temperature without a thermometer

SIGN IN THE KETTLE	APPROXIMATE TEMPERATURE	FOR
Small bubbles at the bottom ("shrimp eyes")	70–80 °C	greens, yellows
Medium bubbles rising ("fish eyes")	80–90 °C	whites, light oolongs
String of pearls at the edge	90–95 °C	oolongs, Darjeeling
Full boil	100 °C	blacks, dark teas, herbs

The names come from Tang-dynasty Chinese tea treatises. Water boiled too long loses oxygen and makes tea flat: boil once, just before brewing.

AT HOME

Gongfu step by step

More leaf, little water, short steeps: the Chinese method that reveals each layer of a tea.

1. **Warm** the gaiwan, pitcher and cups with boiling water.
2. **Weigh** 5 to 7 g of leaf per 100 ml. That is double or triple the Western ratio.
3. **Smell** the dry leaves in the warm gaiwan, covered and shaken.
4. **Rinse** (oolongs and dark teas): 5 s and discard. It wakes the leaf.
5. **Steep short**: start at 10 to 20 s and add 5 to 10 s each round.
6. **Pour everything** into the pitcher, then the cups: no water stays on the leaves.
7. **Continue** until the tea fades: 5 to 15 rounds, depending on the leaf.

STYLE	LEAF / 100 ML	WATER	FIRST STEEP	ROUNDS
White	5 g	85–90 °C	20 s	6–8
Green	4 g	80 °C	15 s	3–4
Oolong	6–7 g	95–100 °C	20 s	8–12
Black	5 g	95 °C	10 s	5–7
Pu-erh	6–7 g	100 °C	10 s	10–15



Thank you for brewing with us

The Botânora collection has ten guides, each devoted to one way of living with tea. Keep exploring:

01 Signature Infusions
03 The Night Ritual
04 Focus & Energy
05 Iced & Cold Brew
06 Matcha at Home
07 Backyard Herbs
08 Crafting Blends
09 Tea & Table
10 Yerba Mate

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